Friday, November 6, 2026

St. Justin Martyr

Martyr and Apologist · Feast, June 1



Saint Justin Martyr, Theophanes the Cretan, 1545–46[1]

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1. Theophanes the Cretan, *Saint Justin Martyr* ("Justin the Philosopher"), 1545–46; Wikimedia Commons.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** Flavia Neapolis, near ancient Shechem in Samaria.[2] [3] His family's names suggest a pagan origin.[4]
- **Born:** about A.D. 100.[5]
- **Died:** about A.D. 165, at Rome,[6] beheaded with six companions after he was condemned by the prefect Rusticus.[7] [8] [9]
- **Feast:** June 1.[10] The Catholic Encyclopedia (1910) gives April 14, the date Leo XIII set.[11]
- **Title:** Apologist. Benedict XVI called him "the most important of the second-century apologist Fathers."[12]

✠ His Life in Brief

Justin was a pagan philosopher before he was a Christian. He studied first under a Stoic and went on to other schools,[13] and by the seashore he met a mysterious old man who pointed him to the prophets.[14] What finally moved him, he wrote, was seeing the Christians: "hearing the accusations made against the Christians and seeing them intrepid in the face of death and of all that men

2. "St. Justin Martyr," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 8 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1910).
3. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin, Philosopher and Martyr," General Audience, March 21, 2007.
4. "St. Justin Martyr," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
5. Ibid.
6. Ibid.
7. Ibid.
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Universalis, Morning Prayer (Lauds) for June 1, 2026, "Saint Justin, Martyr."
11. "St. Justin Martyr," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
12. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin."
13. "St. Justin Martyr," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
14. Ibid.

fear," he concluded that they could not be living in evil.[15] His conversion came no later than about 130.[16]

- He opened a school in Rome and taught the faith as the true philosophy.[17]
- Only three of his works survive with certainty: two *Apologies* and the *Dialogue with Trypho*.[18]
- Around 155 he wrote to the pagan emperor Antoninus Pius to explain what Christians believed and did.[19] He asked for justice: "do not decree death against those who have done no wrong."[20]
- He expected to die for it: "I, too, expect to be persecuted and to be crucified."[21]
- Before Rusticus he answered, "No one in his right mind gives up piety for impiety,"[22] and "That is our desire, to be tortured for Our Lord, Jesus Christ, and so to be saved."[23]

✠ Famous Excerpt: *Second Apology* 13

> *"For each man spoke well in proportion to the share he had of the spermatic word, seeing what was related to it. ... Whatever things were*

15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin."
18. "St. Justin Martyr," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
19. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1345.
20. Justin Martyr, *First Apology*, ch. 68, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).
21. "St. Justin Martyr," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
22. Ibid.
23. Ibid.

> *rightly said among all men, are the property of us Christians."*[24][25]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: the Mass in the second century. Around 155 Justin described Sunday worship to a pagan emperor. The Catechism says his account gives "the basic lines of the order of the Eucharistic celebration," and that they "have stayed the same until our own day for all the great liturgical families" (CCC 1345).[26] In his words, Christians gathered "on the day we call the day of the sun,"[27] heard "the memoirs of the apostles and the writings of the prophets,"[28] rose to pray, brought bread and wine mixed with water to the one presiding, and answered his thanksgiving with "Amen."[29]

Exercise: lay out the parts of today's Mass (readings, homily, prayers of the faithful, offertory, Eucharistic Prayer, Amen, Communion) and have students find each one in Justin's description.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection 1: "The Mass and the Real Presence were later inventions. The early Christians had a simple memorial meal." Writing to a pagan emperor about 155, Justin says of the Eucharist: "not as common bread and common drink do we receive these."[30] He explains that the food "blessed by the prayer of His word … is

24. Justin Martyr, *Second Apology*, ch. 13, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).
25. Ibid.
26. *CCC* 1345.
27. Ibid.
28. Ibid.
29. Ibid.
30. Justin Martyr, *First Apology*, ch. 66, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

the flesh and blood of that Jesus who was made flesh."[31] He also says why Christians meet on Sunday: it is the day of creation and the day Christ rose.[32] Compare 1 Cor 11:23–29.

Objection 2: "Faith and reason are enemies. A philosopher has to choose." Justin was a philosopher who found in the faith "the only sure and profitable philosophy."[33] He held that "Whatever things were rightly said among all men, are the property of us Christians,"[34] so that, as Benedict XVI summed it up, "Christians can draw from it confidently as from a good of their own."[35]

✠ 3. Theology

- **The Logos and the "seeds of truth":** Every person, being rational, shares in the Logos, the eternal Word, and carries within a "seed" by which he can see glimmers of the truth.[36] Christ is that Word in his fullness, and the philosophers saw only a part.[37]
- **One truth, two paths:** Justin held that the Old Testament and Greek philosophy are "like two paths that lead to Christ," so reason and faith do not compete.[38]
- **The Eucharist as real food:** what the Church receives is the flesh and blood of Jesus, not common bread and drink.[39]

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31. Ibid.
32. Justin Martyr, *First Apology*, ch. 67, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).
33. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin."
34. Justin Martyr, *Second Apology* 13.
35. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin."
36. Ibid.
37. Justin Martyr, *Second Apology* 13.
38. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin."
39. Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 66.

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Concluding prayer, Morning Prayer for St. Justin (Liturgy of the Hours, June 1):[40]
Lord God, in a wonderful way, through the folly of the cross, you taught your martyr Saint Justin the surpassing knowledge of Jesus Christ. Heed his prayer for us: dispel every deceiving error, and ground us firmly in our faith.

Practice: Take the old man's counsel to Justin and pray today "that, above all things, the gates of light may be opened to you."[41] Then bring one question you have been avoiding to prayer.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Wherever truth is found, it belongs to Christ,[42] so we can think hard and trust the faith at once, and the way we gather on Sunday to worship is the way Christians were doing it in the second century.[43]

St. Justin, pray for us.

40. *The Liturgy of the Hours*, Morning Prayer, Memorial of St. Justin, Martyr (June 1), concluding prayer.
41. Benedict XVI, "St. Justin."
42. Justin Martyr, *Second Apology* 13.
43. *CCC* 1345.